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ROOMS ON THE WORLD'S ROOF
Left, modern habitat for Indian Army troops in Ladakh; below, the world's highest motorable pass, Umling La, on the Chisumle–Demchok road

In response to Chinese border villages, under India's 'vibrant villages' programme, people living along the border are to be considered strategic assets, and persuaded not to relocate to cities

high-altitude, rugged terrain along the LAC is, quite literally, an uphill task, the introduction of modern equipment like hot-mix plants for speedier laying of roads, remotely operated hydraulic rock drills for hard rock cutting, precision blasting technology, geo-textiles for soil stabilisation and a range of self-propelled snow-cutters/blowers for swifter clearance of snow were considered paramount, and are now part of the BRO's expanding toolbox.

Senior military analyst Maj. Gen. Shashi Asthana (retd) says that China started infrastructure development along the LAC long ago, to gain a substantial lead over India, and has extended its roads, all connected to well-developed highways in the hinterland, right up to the border. The terrain also favours China, as it is much craggier on the Indian side. On this side of the LAC, explains Asthana, the ridges and valleys are not interconnected, leading to difficulties in movement and construction. "Terrain advantage put the Chinese military way ahead of us. There is a lot being done, but we still have to catch up with them. We are still not at par with the Chinese military on border infrastructure," adds Maj. Gen. Asthana.

Moreover, Chinese border defence law favours their agencies involved in development unlike in India, where environmental and other clearances are needed before work can start. Some military planners have even suggested converting about a 100 km area on the border into a 'strategic area' where no clearance is required to initiate infrastructural works. For better efficiency, the government is in the process of creating a dedicated agency for the management of infrastructure along India's borders. The Border Infrastructure Management Authority (BIMA) will be responsible for the development of road, rail, water, power and communications infrastructure along India's borders, including the LAC.

To counter China's plan to build 624 villages in border areas, India has firmed up plans to set up 'vibrant villages' along the LAC, a concept approved in the previous Union budget. Under this, people living in border areas will be considered strategic assets and the programme seeks to prevent them from relocating to areas nearer cities.

Whether consolidating one's border through its human assets or creating durable infrastructure that can support the thousands of troops deployed along the LAC and in Arunachal Pradesh, the Indian military is inching towards gaining some sort of parity with a hyperactive adversary lying in wait. Hopefully, the steady accretion of development will stand it in good stead. ■